



Halemane says there are enough reasons to believe that language changes today happen due to lack of time. "People today may just not have time to elaborate, nor do they have the time to pay attention to every small rule of language. They choose to communicate in the way they like."

He adds, "People using 'E-English' use e-mail and SMS extensively. It is the written form of what they speak, making it look informal. This could well be because youngsters dread order and formality. Fill-Gaps such as 'umm,' 'err,' 'like,' etc., are used just as they are in spoken language... they type as they think."

However, he also believes that language skills are not on the decline: "Technology has not affected spoken language much. The way people use language these days is just another societal transformation. We do not use the language Shakespeare used. And youngsters don't use the English we used 20 years ago."

Professor Crystal says each new technology has changed the language in some way or the other. For example, the advent of printing, and the advent of TV. Think of TV sports commentators, and its peculiar phraseology. The Internet, Crystal says, will effect another technological change, although it would be premature to predict how.

Cr8ive And Po3tic?

Dr Jill Walker, associate professor in the Department of Humanistic Informatics at Norway's University of Bergen, says SMS-speak is "creative, sophisticated and can have poetic beauty when used well."

She says emoticons work well as additional cues for conversation. An "lol" may not always mean "laughing out loud," but it does usually mean that the person is smiling, or is amused. Face-to-face conversations support our language with body language as well. "We need those extra cues in conversation, because we don't have the time to carefully construct each sentence as we do while writing, say, an e-mail or a blog post or an article."

Dr Walker reckons we think faster as a result of SMS-speak. Again, there are two aspects to this: thinking faster might mean that we get more "communication" done in lesser time, but it might also mean that we express less, with only the essentials coming forth, and the nuances lost. That is at the core of what is happening.

There is an increasing tendency to express only that which is necessary to the topic at hand; we are losing out on the finer points. Technology seems to have made us blunter.

However, Halemane makes a point here: that it's change that makes us grow. He also says that we cannot predict whether the trend will continue: Crystal, in his book *Language And The Internet* says, "We can never predict language change, only recognise it once it has happened."

Here's what Dr Walker has to say about the possible evolution of language as technology



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Dr Jill Walker,
Associate Professor,
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forces us—or allows us—to communicate in different and diverse ways: "Look at 'leet'—short for 'elite.' Leet looks a lot like SMS-speak at first glance, but rather than shorten 'you' to 'u,' leet substitutes numbers and other characters for many letters."

"Originating on the Internet, Leet itself is written '1337.' Leet is a cipher, a novel form of English spelling. (See this month's *Bluff your way through* for more on Leet.) It is characterised by non-alphabetical characters that stand in for letters to which they bear a superficial resemblance, as well as by a number of quasi-standard spelling changes such as the substitution of 'z' for final 's.' Leet is traditionally used on the Internet and other online communities, such as bulletin-board systems, sometimes to complement Internet slang or 'chatspeak.'

"There are artistes who write 'codework,' in a kind of pseudo-machine English that has a lot in common with leet. For instance, the artist N N's (apparently, this person's Web identity is that of a woman named Netochka Nezvanova, but no

one knows who he/she really is) words
mor konfused kr!!!!ketz. !
sh!ne m! metal!k zurfazez
modulated b! 01 z!lnz
can be translated into English as
More confused critics (crickets?)
I shine my metallic surfaces modulated by
silence

"There is a certain beauty to it.

Whether languages like these remain slang for sub-cultures and artistic expressions remains to be seen."

There may be a certain beauty to N N's words, and there may be a certain beauty to Shakespeare's sonnets as well. Which will be considered "more beautiful" in the years to come—N N's works or Shakespeare's?

Language: Like Fast Food

What's the problem with chatting the way we do, and in general, communicating the way we do? The answer lies in the articulation of ideas. Consider the following sentence from Arthur Schopenhauer, the influential German philosopher: "No truth therefore is more certain, more independent of all others, and less in need of proof than this, that all that exists for knowledge and therefore this whole world, is only object in relation to subject, perception of a perceiver, in a word, idea."

Schopenhauer was known for his long sentences. However, even though this sentence is long and involved, it is certainly not incomprehensible. But how many people—especially young people—who are used to SMS-speak, would understand this sentence without a second, or even a third, reading? There is a tendency to consume and deliver language like fast food.

The SMS Novel

Earlier this year in July, Chinese writer Qian Fuchang began writing a novel as text messages. The messages would be sent via SMS to would-be readers. He divided his novel, "Outside The Fortress Besieged," into

